



SCARRED FOR LIFE ▲
(From left) CM Biren Singh visits a riot-hit village in Bishnupur; the mother of one of the two girls from the May 4 video. The mob killed her husband and son too when they tried to protect the girls

claim the people of the valley have cornered all developmental benefits due to their political might, while the Meiteis allege they are being increasingly marginalised in their ancestral land. The Meiteis, who were 59 per cent of the population in 1951, stood reduced to 44 per cent in the 2011 count.

The Manipur Land Revenue Act, 1960, remains another irritant as it restricts the non-tribal valley people from buying land in the hills. They can do so only with the consent of district councils, a complicated process. The reverse does not hold true. Since the Act draws its powers from Article 371C of the Constitution, the state assembly can alter this provision only after consulting the Hill Areas Committee. Tribal status for the Meiteis will enable them to circumvent this provision.

Despite being well-aware of the historical background to these tensions, the state government made little preparation to prevent any untoward incident during the massive protest rally, which had brought the differences between the people of the valley and the hills to the fore. Manipur chief minister N. Biren Singh, however, pleads innocence and pins the blame on a larger conspiracy by the protesters. "I have not said yes to the court directive yet," he told INDIA TODAY. "Why was the tribal march organised in the first place? That shows it was just an excuse to execute a larger design of the illegal immigrants and drug lords to foment violence in the state." (*See interview.*) But ask him why the state intelligence failed to sense this "design" earlier so that adequate preventive measures could be taken, and Biren is at a loss for words.

NOT ONLY DID THE GOVERNMENT FAIL TO ANTICIPATE THE PROTESTS AND PREPARE FOR IT, ITS INACTION ALSO ALLOWED THE FREE LOOT OF WEAPONS FROM THE POLICE ARMOURY

Call it failure or complicity, the state government's inaction allowed the simultaneous loot of 4,000 weapons and thousands of rounds of ammunition from police armouries. Ethnic loyalty overruled professional integrity at every level. So if, on May 4, arms were being looted from a Manipur police training centre and a camp of the 8th Manipur Rifles and 7th India Reserve battalion in Meitei-dominated Pangei in Imphal valley, similar scenes were witnessed in police stations and training centres in the Kuki-majority Churachandpur district that very day. Police guards on both sides—mostly Meiteis in Pangei and Kukis in Churachandpur—voluntarily facilitated the loot so that their respective communities could arm themselves against aggressors, according to multiple